That Which We Take for Granted

By Joy Harjo, Robert Wrigley, Elise Paschen and Charlotte Mew

Once the World Was Perfect by Joy Harjo

Once the world was perfect, and we were happy in that world.
Then we took it for granted.
Discontent began a small rumble in the earthly mind.
Then Doubt pushed through with its spiked head.
And once Doubt ruptured the web,
All manner of demon thoughts
Jumped through—
We destroyed the world we had been given
For inspiration, for life—
Each stone of jealousy, each stone
Of fear, greed, envy, and hatred, put out the light.
No one was without a stone in his or her hand.
There we were,

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Right back where we had started.
We were bumping into each other
In the dark.
And now we had no place to live, since we didn't know
How to live with each other.
Then one of the stumbling ones took pity on another
And shared a blanket.
A spark of kindness made a light.
The light made an opening in the darkness.
Everyone worked together to make a ladder.
A Wind Clan person climbed out first into the next world,
And then the other clans, the children of those clans, their children,
And their children, all the way through time—
To now, into this morning light to you.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Joy Harjo
Book: Conflict Resolution for Holy Beings, Pg 14-15
ISBN: 978-0393353631
Publisher: W.W. Norton and Company
Date (Month/Year): January 2017

INTRODUCTION

Water, animal life, trees . . . Our native American ancestors recognized the value of nature. When did we, as a society, start taking our natural world for granted? The statistics are staggering. The US Environmental Protection Agency reports that Americans dump 16 tons of sewage into our waterways every minute. And according to the World Resources Institute, 100 animal species die each day due to deforestation.

Nature is all around us, yet we have become so intent on fighting each other that we seem to have forgotten the very planet that sustains us. Albert Einstein once said: "There are only two ways to live your life. One is as if nothing is a miracle. The other is as if everything is a miracle."

That Which We Take for Granted – A collection containing Once the World was Perfect by Joy Harjo, Little Deaths by Robert Wrigley, The Tree Agreement by Elise Paschen and The Trees are Down by Charlotte Mew.

Little Deaths by Robert Wrigley

Every minute or two, another moth
blunders through the candle flame – a dusty puff,
then silence. Some fall
half-sealed in wax, others spin

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half-charred across the table.
By the handful every hour
I toss them in the stove.

How easy it is to live with
little deaths – mostly bugs,
the less musical birds, the cats
and rabbits we can't avoid in our cars.

In the woods behind their summer camp
Pentecostal kids crucified frogs
to the trees. Three nails
and a sapling trunk, little fish-belly
amphibious Jesus.
There's no accounting for this,
though I fear salvation
is an enterprise, grace the bottom line.

Tonight I'm alone at the cabin.
There's no blood on my hands,
Now and then one of the candle-seared moths
skitters off the table and the dog rouses
and noses it until it's dead.

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A few of the livelier ones she's eaten.
Now she sleeps by the stove and sometimes whimpers
and seems to run. I should out-live her by years,
though I think of her dreams and wonder,
whimpering that way, if she is the one who chases.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Robert Wrigley
Book: Poetry Magazine, Vol. 162, No. 1, Pg 33-34
ISBN: Currently out of Print
Publisher: Poetry Foundation
Date (Month/Year): April 1993

NOTE: JSTOR and the Poetry Foundation have collaborated to digitize, preserve, and extend access to Poetry Magazine – Poem can be found on-line at https://www.poetryfoundation.org/poetrymagazine/browse?contentId=38610

The Tree Agreement by Elise Paschen

The neighbor calls the *Siberian Elm*
a "weed" tree, demands we hack
it down, says the leaves overwhelm
his property, the square backyard.

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He's collar-and-tie. A weed tree?
Branches screen buildings, subway tracks,
his patch of yard. We disagree,
claim back the sap, heartwood, wild bark.

He declares the tree "hazardous."
We shelter under leaf-hoard, crossway
for squirrels, branch house for sparrows, jays.
The balcony soaks up the shade.

Chatter-song drowns out cars below.
Sun branches down. Leaves overwhelm.
The tree will stay. We tell him "no."
Root deep through pavement, *Elm*.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Elise Paschen
Book: The Nightlife: Poems
ISBN: 978-1597090278
Publisher: Red Hen Press
Date (Month/Year): May 2017

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The Trees are Down by Charlotte Mew

—and he cried with a loud voice:
Hurt not the earth, neither the sea, nor the trees—
(Revelation 7:3 KJV)

They are cutting down the great plane-trees at the end of
the gardens.
For days there has been the grate of the saw, the swish of
the branches as they fall,
The crash of the trunks, the rustle of trodden leaves,
With the 'Whoops' and the 'Whoas,' the loud common talk,
the loud common laughs of the men, above it all.

I remember one evening of a long past Spring
Turning in at a gate, getting out of a cart, and finding a large
dead rat in the mud of the drive.
I remember thinking: alive or dead, a rat was a god-
forsaken thing,
But at least, in May, that even a rat should be alive.

The week's work here is as good as done. There is just one
bough
On the roped bole, in the fine grey rain,

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Green and high
And lonely against the sky.
(Down now!—)
And but for that,
If an old dead rat
Did once, for a moment, unmake the Spring, I might never
have thought of him again.

It is not for a moment the Spring is unmade to-day;
These were great trees, it was in them from root to stem:
When the men with the 'Whoops' and the 'Whoas' have
carted the whole of the whispering loveliness away
Half the Spring, for me, will have gone with them.

It is going now, and my heart has been struck with the
hearts of the planes;
Half my life it has beat with these, in the sun, in the rains,
In the March wind, the May breeze,
In the great gales that came over to them across the roofs
from the great seas.
There was only a quiet rain when they were dying;
They must have heard the sparrows flying,

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And the small creeping creatures in the earth where they

were lying—

But I, all day, I heard an angel crying:

'Hurt not the trees.'

From Poem #1: [You see] Once the world was perfect, and

we were happy in that world.

Then we took it for granted.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Charlotte Mew
Book: Collected Poems and Prose, Pg 52
ISBN: 978-0415967570
Publisher: Routledge
Date (Month/Year): March 2003

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